TGS-2024043854 · DAY 1 · TOPIC 2 SETUP · 120 MIN

Hire Your First AI Employee — Hermes Agent Setup

Build a Human-AI Workforce with Autonomous AI Agents · One agent, many tools · LO1/LO2

> Install Hermes Desktop, give it a brain, put it on Telegram, arm it with tools and skills, then let it read your inbox and brief you every morning.

The business scenario

You are the founder-CEO of Kopi Kaki Co., a fictional Singapore kopi startup. The Tiong Bahru flagship opens on 1 Dec 2026 with the Gula Melaka Cold Brew (SGD 6.80, #ShiokColdBrew); until then you sell at weekend pop-ups and take app pre-orders. Your team is two baristas — and the AI agents you set up in this course. Today your first hire is Mia, a Hermes agent that works from your laptop: she reads your Kopi Kaki inbox and calendar, searches the web for cold-brew trends, and messages you a summary on Telegram every morning before you open the pop-up.

You will deliver

- Hermes Desktop running in ~/kopi-kaki with a working model (MiniMax demo or the trainer-assigned provider)
- Mia answering you on Telegram from your allow-listed user ID
- Tools and skills listed and tested; Firecrawl web search returning cited results
- gog reading Gmail and Calendar; one approved test email sent
- A daily 8:00 email-summary cron that delivers to Telegram

Agents: 1 Hermes agent — Mia, your first AI employee
You (the human): Choose the model and accounts, approve every send, own the schedule
Goal: Set up one Hermes Agent with a model, a messaging channel, tools, reviewed skills, web search, Google Workspace access and a schedule, and explain how each part changes what the agent can do (LO1, LO2).

Before you start

- Laptop: macOS 12+ on Apple Silicon (Intel Macs are not supported by the Desktop installer), Windows 10/11, or Linux
- A Telegram account on your phone
- The trainer-assigned training Google account and OAuth client file (from Lab 1)
- A model provider: a MiniMax account (demo) or the provider key your trainer assigns
- A free Firecrawl account (firecrawl.dev — 1,000 free credits a month, no card)

Lab files (data/)

File	What it is

`AGENTS.md`	Company context Hermes loads automatically
`brand-guide.md`	Brand voice, colours, platform formats
`campaign-brief.md`	Gula Melaka Cold Brew campaign brief (offer, KPIs, timeline)
`compliance-rules.md`	C1–C10 brand-safety and escalation rules
`product-catalogue.csv`	12 products and prices
`competitors.csv`	6 fictional competitors
`customer-reviews.csv`	60 synthetic customer reviews
`assets/brand-palette.png`	Brand image asset
`assets/cold-brew-product-card.png`	Brand image asset
`assets/kopi-kaki-logo.png`	Brand image asset
`skills/gog-office/SKILL.md`	Agent skill (SKILL.md)
`approved-test-send.md`	Procedure for the one approved test email

All company data in this lab (Kopi Kaki Co., people, reviews, comments, metrics, competitors) is fictional and generated for training.

Steps

1. Create the Kopi Kaki workspace (5 min)

Everything your agents do for the startup happens in one folder. AGENTS.md tells every agent who Kopi Kaki is and the rules; Hermes loads it automatically when it starts in that folder. The small Python environment is used by the PPT and image tools later.

TERMINAL

```
mkdir -p ~/kopi-kaki && cp -Rn data/* ~/kopi-kaki/
cd ~/kopi-kaki
python3 -m venv .office-venv
.office-venv/bin/python -m pip install python-pptx openpyxl Pillow
ls
```

✓ Expected: ~/kopi-kaki holds AGENTS.md, brand-guide.md, campaign-brief.md, the reviews and competitor files and skills/.

2. Install Hermes Desktop (10 min)

Download the installer for your laptop from the official page: Hermes-Setup.dmg (Mac, Apple Silicon) or Hermes-Setup.exe (Windows). On Linux install the CLI, then run `hermes desktop`. On first run, choose 'Choose provider later' — you connect the model in the next step — and pick the Basic layout. Data lives in ~/.hermes (Windows: %LOCALAPPDATA%\hermes).

TERMINAL

```
# Download: https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/desktop
# CLI (macOS / Linux / WSL2):
curl -fsSL https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.sh | bash
# CLI (Windows PowerShell):
iex (irm https://hermes-agent.nousresearch.com/install.ps1)
hermes --version
hermes desktop
```

✓ Expected: Hermes Desktop opens; `hermes --version` prints a version.

3. Connect a model — demo with MiniMax (10 min)

The model is the agent's brain. Hermes has MiniMax built in. Run `hermes model`, choose MiniMax → MiniMax (OAuth) and sign in in the browser, or choose 'MiniMax (global endpoint)' and paste your M Plan subscription key. Then choose 'Enter custom model name' and type MiniMax-M3.1-Flash. In Desktop the same setting is Settings → Providers, then Settings → Model → Main model → Apply. Trial offer: your trainer will confirm any current MiniMax free trial on the day (awaiting verification); MiniMax's published options are the M Plan and pay-as-you-go credits. Use the trainer-assigned provider if you have no MiniMax access.

TERMINAL

```
hermes model                       # MiniMax → MiniMax (OAuth), or global endpoint + key
# key alternative: add to ~/.hermes/.env
#   MINIMAX_API_KEY=your-key
# model name: MiniMax-M3.1-Flash
hermes chat -q "Say hello in one line as Mia, Kopi Kaki's first AI employee."
```

✓ Expected: A one-line reply from the model.

4. Meet Mia: your first AI employee (5 min)

Start a Desktop chat with the working folder set to ~/kopi-kaki so AGENTS.md is loaded, and check that Mia knows the company.

PROMPT — PASTE INTO HERMES DESKTOP — NEW CHAT, FOLDER ~/KOPI-KAKI

```
You are Mia, the first AI employee of Kopi Kaki Co. Read AGENTS.md and campaign-brief.md. In five
bullets: who we are, what we launch and when, the price, our KPIs, and the three rules you must
never break.
```

✓ Expected: Five correct bullets: startup, Gula Melaka Cold Brew on 1 Dec 2026, SGD 6.80, the KPIs and the rules.

5. Put Mia on Telegram (10 min)

In Telegram open @BotFather → /newbot → choose a name (e.g. Mia Kopi Kaki) and a username ending in 'bot' → copy the token. Get your numeric user ID from @userinfobot. Only allow-listed users can talk to your agent. Desktop shortcut: Messaging → Telegram → Create with QR does all of this for you.

TERMINAL

```
hermes gateway setup          # choose Telegram, paste the token and your user ID
# or add to ~/.hermes/.env:
#   TELEGRAM_BOT_TOKEN=...
#   TELEGRAM_ALLOWED_USERS=123456789
hermes gateway                # keep running (service: hermes gateway install && hermes gateway
start; WSL: hermes gateway run)
```

✓ Expected: Send 'hi' to your bot — Mia replies. Then send /sethome in that chat so scheduled results arrive there.

6. Configure Mia's tools (5 min)

Tools are what the agent can actually do: web, terminal, files, browser, images, voice, cron and more. Switch on only what the job needs (Principle 2: permission control).

TERMINAL

```
hermes tools --summary
hermes tools                  # tick or untick toolsets per platform
hermes tools disable browser --platform telegram
```

✓ Expected: The summary lists the enabled toolsets for CLI and Telegram.

7. Review, then install skills (10 min)

A skill is a SKILL.md folder of know-how the agent loads when a task matches it. Read every third-party skill before you install it. Start with the reviewed gog-office skill in this lab's data/, then browse the hub.

TERMINAL

```
cat ~/kopi-kaki/skills/gog-office/SKILL.md
mkdir -p ~/.hermes/skills/productivity && cp -R ~/kopi-kaki/skills/gog-office
~/.hermes/skills/productivity/
hermes skills list
hermes skills browse
hermes skills search marketing
```

✓ Expected: gog-office appears in hermes skills list.

8. Give Mia web search with Firecrawl (5 min)

Firecrawl is Hermes's default web backend. Create a free key at firecrawl.dev (1,000 credits a month, no card) and add it to Hermes. Then ask a real question.

TERMINAL

```
echo 'FIRECRAWL_API_KEY=fc-your-key' >> ~/.hermes/.env
hermes tools                  # confirm the web toolset is on
```

PROMPT — PASTE INTO HERMES DESKTOP — MIA

```
Search the web for 3 news items from the last 90 days about cold brew or kopi trends in Singapore.
For each: headline, date, URL and one takeaway for Kopi Kaki's launch. Mark anything you could not
verify. Save it to outputs/research/trends.md.
```

✓ Expected: Three dated items with URLs in outputs/research/trends.md.

9. Connect gog: read Gmail and check Calendar (10 min)

gog (gogcli) is a Google Workspace command-line tool Mia drives from the terminal. Sign in once with the trainer-assigned training account and its OAuth client. Read-only first.

TERMINAL

```
brew install openclaw/tap/gogcli        # or: go install github.com/openclaw/gogcli/cmd/gog@latest
gog auth credentials set ~/Downloads/training-oauth-client.json
export GOG_ACCOUNT="REPLACE_WITH_ASSIGNED_GOOGLE_EMAIL"
gog auth add "$GOG_ACCOUNT" --services gmail,calendar
gog auth doctor --check
gog --account "$GOG_ACCOUNT" gmail search 'is:unread newer_than:7d' --max 10 --json
gog --account "$GOG_ACCOUNT" calendar events --today --json
```

PROMPT — PASTE INTO HERMES DESKTOP — MIA

```
Use gog with the gog-office skill (account $GOG_ACCOUNT, read-only). List my unread Kopi Kaki
emails from the last 7 days and today's calendar events in Asia/Singapore time. Flag any clash,
any supplier or landlord email that needs a reply today, and anything that looks like phishing. Do
not send or change anything.
```

✓ Expected: A short brief with message IDs, event times (+08:00) and flagged items.

10. Send ONE approved email (5 min)

Sending is a separate permission. Mia drafts, you approve the exact text, then she sends once to the trainer-approved test address and shows the message ID. Re-authorise with send access only for this step if your account was added read-only.

TERMINAL

```
gog --account "$GOG_ACCOUNT" gmail send --to TRAINER_TEST_ADDRESS --subject "Kopi Kaki tasting — Thursday 3 pm" --body "…approved text…"
```

PROMPT — PASTE INTO HERMES DESKTOP — MIA

```
Draft a reply to the supplier tasting email confirming Thursday 3 pm at the Tiong Bahru flagship. Show me the exact To, Subject and Body. Wait for my SEND. After I say SEND, send it once with gog gmail send to the trainer-approved test address, show the message ID and confirm it is in Sent.
```

✓ Expected: One message ID and a Sent record — nothing sent before your SEND.

11. Make Mia proactive: cron basics (5 min)

Cron makes the agent start work without being asked. Jobs run inside the gateway, which checks for due jobs every minute — keep it running.

TERMINAL

```
hermes cron list
hermes cron status
# a test job you can delete afterwards:
hermes cron create "every 2h" "Remind me to post the pop-up photo." --name test-reminder --deliver telegram
hermes cron run <job_id>
hermes cron remove <job_id>
```

✓ Expected: The test reminder arrives on Telegram, then the job is removed.

12. Schedule the daily 8:00 email summary (5 min)

Your morning brief before you open the pop-up: Mia reads the inbox at 8:00 Singapore time and messages you on Telegram. Reading only — the cron job never sends email.

TERMINAL

```
hermes cron create "0 8 * * *" "Summarise my unread Kopi Kaki Gmail from the last 24 hours with gog (read-only): urgent items first, then replies needed, then FYI. Add today's calendar events and any clash. Never send or change anything." --skill gog-office --name "Morning email brief" --deliver telegram --timezone Asia/Singapore
hermes cron list
hermes cron run <job_id>
```

✓ Expected: Your test run delivers a structured email summary to Telegram; the job is listed for 08:00 daily.

Verification / checkpoint

- □ Desktop runs in ~/kopi-kaki with a working model

- □ Mia replies on Telegram only to your user ID
- □ hermes tools --summary and hermes skills list show the expected tools and gog-office
- □ trends.md has three dated items with URLs
- □ gog reads Gmail and Calendar; one approved email has a message ID
- □ `hermes cron list` shows 'Morning email brief' at 08:00 Asia/Singapore

Checkpoint: Mia answers on Telegram, lists her tools and skills, returns cited web results, reads your inbox and calendar, and `hermes cron list` shows the 8:00 email summary.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Fix
`hermes: command not found`	Open a new terminal or run `source ~/.zshrc` (macOS) / `source ~/.bashrc` (Linux/WSL2).
MiniMax sign-in works but replies fail	Check the plan/credits on platform.minimax.io; re-run `hermes model` and type the model name exactly.
Bot silent on Telegram	Is the gateway running? `hermes gateway status`; check TELEGRAM_ALLOWED_USERS has your numeric ID.
Cron never fires	The gateway must be running; check `hermes cron status`. Results go to the /sethome chat.
gog: access blocked	Use the trainer's OAuth client and the assigned account; run `gog auth doctor --check`.
Web search returns nothing	Check FIRECRAWL_API_KEY in ~/.hermes/.env and that the web toolset is enabled.

Stretch challenge

Add a second cron at 18:00 that summarises the day's pre-orders and emails into three lines on Telegram. Which part of the job would you never let a cron do unattended?

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